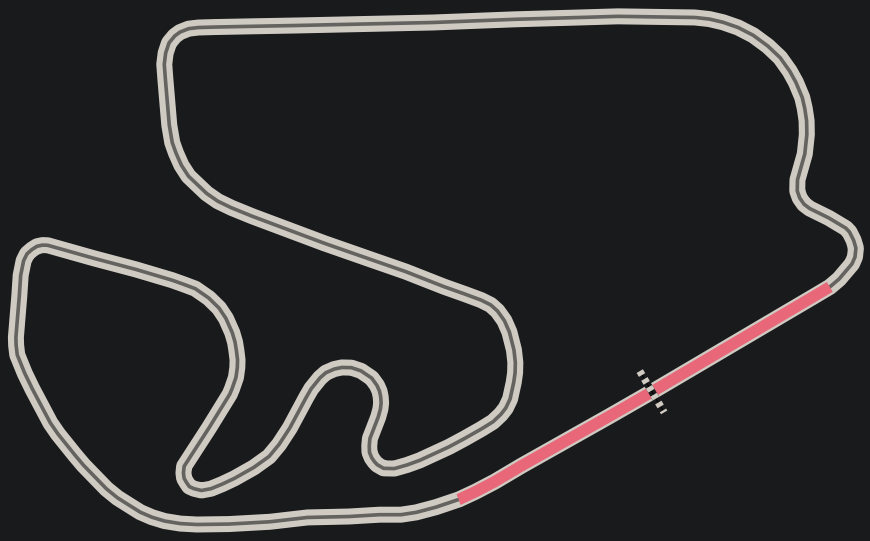
JP Motorsport Journal
EST. 2026 · JP RACE DAY PROGRAMME

EDITION
03
ROUND 20 OF 23

JP RACE DAY · SÃO PAULO GRAND PRIX

Storm warning at Interlagos



SUNDAY 8 NOVEMBER 2026 AUTÓDROMO JOSÉ CARLOS PACE · INTERLAGOS, SÃO PAULO RACE 14:00 BRT

Lando Norris starts on pole after a wet qualifying, Verstappen, Hamilton and Pérez start from the back, and rain is forecast for Sunday afternoon.

Antonelli clinched the championship in Mexico City with third place, the youngest champion in Formula 1 history. Verstappen's win there lifted him to second, two points ahead of Hamilton. Interlagos is a standard weekend this year: three practice sessions, qualifying on Saturday and the 71-lap race on Sunday, on a track where the weather and the Safety Car often have the final say.

01 **Four drivers, 16 points** VERIFIED

Verstappen (261), Hamilton (259), Russell (250) and Leclerc (245) are fighting to finish runner-up to Antonelli, with 100 points left.

02 **Mercedes' title point** ANALYSIS

Mercedes lead Ferrari by 126 in the Constructors'. Outscore Ferrari by four points or more on Sunday and the teams' title is theirs too.

03 **Expect the unexpected** VERIFIED

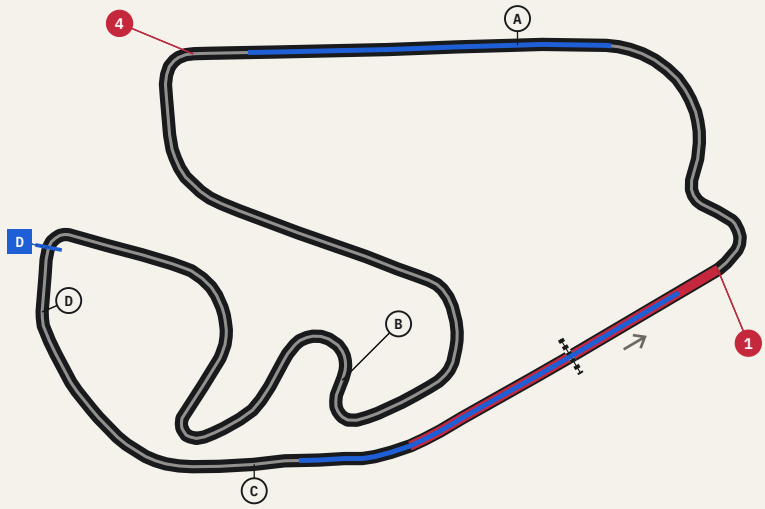
Formula 1 puts the chance of a Safety Car here at 86%, based on the last seven races, and Interlagos weather can turn in minutes.

P1	P2	P3	P4	P5
Antonelli	Verstappen	Hamilton	Russell	Leclerc
380	261	259	250	245

02 · THE CIRCUIT FILE

Autódromo José Carlos Pace

Fifteen corners, anticlockwise, up and down a natural bowl: the Senna S, the Reta Oposta, a twisting infield and the long climb past the pits.



Ⓐ Reta Oposta Ⓑ Infield Ⓒ Climb to the line Ⓓ Junção

Straight Mode zone D Overtake detection

Zones at approximate positions, from the FIA's description; detection about 3,250 m into the lap.

Red: start/finish straight · Arrow: direction of travel · Numbered: corners confirmed from the official outline; full numbering pending a check against the FIA map. Outline: f1-circuits (MIT).

CIRCUIT LENGTH	4.309 km VERIFIED
RACE LAPS	71 VERIFIED
RACE DISTANCE	305.879 km VERIFIED
CORNERS	15 (run anticlockwise) VERIFIED
FIRST GRAND PRIX	1973 VERIFIED
RACE LAP RECORD	1:10.540, Valtteri Bottas (2018) VERIFIED
SAFETY CAR CHANCE	86% (last seven races) VERIFIED

Overtaking aids VERIFIED
Two Straight Mode zones: the start/finish straight into Turn 1 and the Reta Oposta from Turn 3 to Turn 4. Overtake Mode detection is at the exit of Junção, with activation on the climb after Turn 13.

The Senna S ANALYSIS

Turn 1 drops sharply downhill and left, straight into the right of Turn 2. It is the main overtaking spot at the start of a lap and the scene of many first-lap collisions.

Reta Oposta ANALYSIS

After Curva do Sol, the back straight runs down to Turn 4, Descida do Lago: the second big braking zone and the next chance to pass.

The infield ANALYSIS

A slow, twisting run of corners through the middle of the lap. It is hard to pass here, so drivers aim for a clean exit before the climb.

Junção and the climb ANALYSIS

Junção, the last slow corner, opens a long, flat-out uphill run past the pits to Turn 1. A good exit is worth a tow all the way to the Senna S.

> **The lap hinges on Junção: get out of it well and the long climb carries the car into the Senna S with a chance to pass.** ANALYSIS

Terms used in this programme

Undercut Pitting before a rival to use new tyres' extra pace to get ahead when they stop.

Degradation How quickly a tyre loses grip and lap time as it wears.

Straight Mode 2026 active aero: wings flatten to cut drag in designated zones. Replaces DRS.

Overcut Staying out longer than a rival to gain time while they warm up new tyres or sit in traffic.

VSC Virtual Safety Car: everyone must slow to a set pace; positions are frozen and no one may overtake.

Overtake Mode Extra electrical energy for a car within one second of the car ahead at the detection point.

Pit window The range of laps when a stop makes strategic sense.

Safety Car A physical car leads the field at reduced speed, bunching everyone up behind it.

Parc fermé From qualifying until the race, cars cannot be changed without a penalty.

VERIFIED official source MEASURED computed from timing data or the outline ESTIMATE sourced estimate
ANALYSIS our editorial view

03 · THE STRATEGY DESK

What a pit stop really costs

Time in the pit lane is not the same as time lost. What matters is the race time a stop costs compared with staying out, and that changes when the race is neutralised.

CONDITIONS	TIME IN PIT LANE	NET RACE-TIME LOSS	SAVING VS GREEN
Green flag	about 24 s MEASURED	about 21 s ESTIMATE	–
Virtual Safety Car	about 24 s MEASURED	about 13–17 s ESTIMATE	about 4–8 s
Safety Car	about 24 s MEASURED	about 8–14 s ESTIMATE	about 7–12 s

- Time in the pit lane is measured: the median from pit entry to pit exit at Interlagos was 23.2–24.0 s in 2019, 2022, 2023 and 2025 (f1db timing data); the wet, red-flagged 2024 race skews it. It does not change under a VSC or Safety Car because the pit-lane speed limit still applies.
- Net race-time loss is what a stop costs compared with staying out. Formula 1's 2025 preview put it at about 20.8 s here.
- The VSC and Safety Car figures apply published estimates of the saving (roughly 17–40% under a VSC and 35–60% behind the Safety Car) to that 20.8 s. They are illustrative ranges, not Interlagos measurements.

TYRE STRATEGY VERIFIED

Pirelli's projection after qualifying: two stops is the quickest plan, with two soft stints and one on the medium. A soft-hard-soft race is slower, and one stop is about ten seconds slower than the best two-stop. Pirelli puts a stop at 22.5 seconds. Rain would rewrite all of it.

Two stops Pirelli's quickest	Soft → Medium → Soft	Two stints on the soft and one on the medium.
Two stops Slower	Soft → Hard → Soft	Using the hard adds overall race time.
One stop About 10 s slower		Significantly less competitive in the dry; compound order not published.

PACE GAP PER LAP Not published by Pirelli for this race.

Soft (C5) Medium (C4) Hard (C3)

Pirelli qualifying release, 7 Nov 2026, as reported; pit-stop cost 22.5 s (Pirelli preview).

RACE-DAY WEATHER ESTIMATE

13–19°C SUNDAY RANGE **40–50%** RAIN CHANCE **16°C** AT LIGHTS OUT

Cool and unsettled. Rain is forecast through the morning and possibly into the afternoon, so the race could start wet or on a drying track.

Formula 1	13–19°C, 40% chance of heavy rain and thunderstorms
AccuWeather	16°C and a 47% chance of rain at 14:00; showers through the morning
Other models	Rain risk from 40% to over 70% (Autohebdo); as low as 10% (FMOverseer)

Forecasts as published on 7 November. Interlagos weather can change within minutes.

Pirelli has nominated C3 (hard), C4 (medium) and C5 (soft), the softest three in its range and one step softer than last year. VERIFIED

UNDERCUT AND OVERCUT

Undercut: pit first and use the new tyres' extra grip to gain the time you lose in the pit lane before your rival stops. It works best when new tyres are much faster than worn ones.

Overcut: stay out longer and gain time on a clear track while your rival is held up on cold new tyres or in traffic. It works best when tyres warm up slowly or the pitting car rejoins in traffic.

IF THE VSC OR SAFETY CAR COMES OUT

A VSC or Safety Car inside the pit window makes a stop cheaper for everyone, so the leaders often pit together and little changes. The real swing comes when it falls just before a team's planned stop, or when a rival has already stopped under green. A Safety Car early in the race can make a one-stop too long and force a second stop. ANALYSIS

What to Watch

1. The start into the Senna S. The downhill Turn 1 is the best place to gain, and to lose, positions on lap one.
2. Safety Car timing. With an 86% chance of one, a neutralisation can turn a two-stop race on its head.
3. Mercedes against Ferrari. Four more points than Ferrari on Sunday and the Constructors' title is settled.

04 · THE VIEWER'S BRIEFING

Your race-day reference

14:00 BRT — LIGHTS OUT · SUNDAY 8 NOVEMBER 2026 BRT (UTC−3), LOCAL TIME IN SÃO PAULO

Weekend schedule VERIFIED

Fri 6 Nov	Practice 1	12:30 BRT
Fri 6 Nov	Practice 2	16:00 BRT
Sat 7 Nov	Practice 3	11:30 BRT
Sat 7 Nov	Qualifying	15:00 BRT
Sun 8 Nov	**Grand Prix (71 laps)**	**14:00 BRT**

Starting grid

1	Lando Norris	2	Kimi Antonelli
3	Liam Lawson	4	Nico Hülkenberg
5	Isack Hadjar	6	Oliver Bearman
7	George Russell Q2, −5 places	8	Fernando Alonso
9	Alexander Albon	10	Oscar Piastri
11	Rafael Câmara	12	Arvid Lindblad
13	Carlos Sainz	14	Charles Leclerc Q4, −10 places
15	Franco Colapinto	16	Pierre Gasly
17	Lance Stroll	18	Valtteri Bottas
19	Gabriel Bortoleto	20	Lewis Hamilton back of grid
21	Max Verstappen back of grid	22	Sergio Pérez back of grid

After announced power-unit penalties (in red); the FIA confirms the grid, including the order of the last three, before the race. Pole: Norris, 1:27.470 (wet).

Key battles

Runner-up	Verstappen 261, Hamilton 259, Russell 250, Leclerc 245.
Constructors	Mercedes 630, Ferrari 504: 126 clear, 172 left.
Constructors P3	Red Bull 382 vs McLaren 365.
Constructors P5	Racing Bulls 108 vs Alpine 69.

Standings entering the race VERIFIED

POS	DRIVER	PTS
1	Kimi Antonelli	380
2	Max Verstappen	261
3	Lewis Hamilton	259
4	George Russell	250
5	Charles Leclerc	245
6	Lando Norris	221
7	Oscar Piastri	144
8	Isack Hadjar	107
9	Liam Lawson	83
10	Pierre Gasly	42

POS	CONSTRUCTOR	PTS
1	Mercedes	630
2	Ferrari	504
3	Red Bull	382
4	McLaren	365
5	Racing Bulls	108

Five things to watch

1. The start into the Senna S, downhill and left: the best chance of the lap to gain places, and the riskiest.
2. The fight for second. Two points split Verstappen and Hamilton, with Russell and Leclerc within 16.
3. Mercedes' Constructors' title. Outscore Ferrari by four points or more and it is settled with three races to spare.
4. Safety Cars and weather. Formula 1 puts the Safety Car chance at 86%; watch the skies above the grandstands.
5. Antonelli's first race as champion, at the track where he took second place last year.

JP'S PREDICTION

Interlagos never sticks to the script, and this year the chaos started before the lights: rain in the forecast, Leclerc down in 14th and Hamilton, Verstappen and Pérez at the back. As a Ferrari fan it hurts, but it sets up a great race. I have Lando Norris converting pole into the win, with Max Verstappen charging from the back onto the podium.

— JP

Sources (last verified 7 November 2026)
f1db, results and pit stops 2019–2025 (CC BY 4.0): github.com
f1-circuits, track outline (MIT): github.com
VSC and SC savings: FormulaDream; Race Sundays: formuladream.app
2026 aero rules: ESPN; Motor Sport: motorsportmagazine.com
Circuit facts: Formula1.com: formula1.com
Pirelli compounds: Coffee Corner Motorsport: coffeecornermotorsport.com
Pit loss 20.8 s and Safety Car chance: Formula1.com 2025 preview: formula1.com
Session times: F1 Fansite; f1db: f1-fansite.com
Standings after Round 19 (checked against f1db): github.com
Grid: The Race; Yahoo Sports; Formula1.com: formula1.com
Penalties: Sky Sports; Motorsport Week: skysports.com
Aero zones: PlanetF1; Scuderiafans: planetf1.com
Pirelli qualifying release: press.pirelli.com
Weather: Formula1.com; GPFans (AccuWeather): formula1.com